been cleared by the English Parliament, and upbeat companies that had been set up were in the process of constructing railway lines—at Bombay in the west and Howrah in the east—when what can be referred to as the ‘first-of-its-kind’ steam locomotive quietly made its way into the subcontinent to assist the canal works along the Ganges. The Ganges Canal Works was a large-scale irrigation project that commenced in 1845. As part of this project, an aqueduct was constructed to carry the Solani river water across the Ganges canal at Roorkee. The locomotive arrived here and was named Thomason—after the Lieutenant Governor of the North-west Provinces at the time, James Thomason. It ran successfully for sometime but eventually died due to a blast in its boiler. Evidence suggests that after this incident it worked as a stationary machine for canal work.

The life and times of the locomotive Thomason and the railway that was built to facilitate the canal work are discussed in detail by Sir Proby T. Cautley, the director of the Ganges Canal Works, in the second volume of his detailed three-volume ‘Report on the Ganges canal works from their commencement until the opening of the canal in 1854’, on the construction of the canal. The locomotive Thomason lived a short life—from December 1851 until April 1852.

However, the locomotive proved to be helpful during the short period in which it functioned, as Captain Cautley, at one point, says, ‘During the month of April, the work of the locomotive has shown a considerable improvement, and once the engine had brought 114 loads during a day. But during this operation, the working of the locomotive was stopped.’ [23] A table next to this description states that the locomotive worked only for ten days in April 1852, drawing 687 loads, carrying 34,350 cubic feet of earth and running for about 14,000 feet.

Follwing is the interesting description of the railway system along the canals—its utility, the locomotive and its death—in Captain Cautley’s own words. [24]

THE SYSTEM

> A system of railways, connected with the brick manufactories which had been established at Roorkee and Muhewur, that is to say, at each end of the aqueduct. The railways were necessarily a main feature in the earthen aqueduct, as it was through their aid that the embankments would be formed.